A NIGHT TO REMEMBER

URSULA WEST

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THE CROWD FROM JERUSALEM

Bina lay back with a soft thump on her bed. It was three in the afternoon and every muscle in her body melted into the rough blanket beneath her. She stretched out her legs and clasped her hands together behind her head, her thick dark curls spilling over the pillow. She stared at the wooden roof above her head and let out a long slow breath.

"What a day" she mumbled. Bethlehem could be a busy place. The market always swelled the population at least once a week, making it appear like a bustling city which it certainly wasn't. Then, as if by magic, the streets and alleyways would return to their normal quiet, sleepy self.

Today was different. There was no market but at first light, scores of people had arrived, all at the same time. They had journeyed together in a group from Jerusalem, only five miles away, to stay with relatives so that they could be present when the census officials arrived. Normally, that could be any time between now and whenever, but in Jerusalem the word had gone out that Bethlehem was the next town on the list. There were hundreds who made a dash

back to their countryside homeland. According to the law, that is where they had to be for the census. The overspill from the family lodgers had booked into the few rooms they had at the Inn and the rest took up residence on the floor of the large open public room. Quite frankly, it was chaos.

She had had to stuff at least seven extra cloth pallets with straw and there was hardly any floorspace left in the whole inn. She had counted 21 guests. Six or seven was normally a full house. Hopefully, it would all get back to normal in a few days. They were satisfied that they had done what they could to help.

Much of the work had fallen to her since the innkeeper and his wife were getting on in years. Nathanael and Tamar were probably fast asleep already. She smiled as she remembered Nathanael's look of shock as he watched the group swarming into the inn. How quickly it had turned to excitement when he realised what a windfall this was. She did not mind the extra work, in fact she was happy for her employers, happy to see Nathanael laugh and joke with his clients while organising them in a clear, no-nonsense way. His customers enjoyed his banter but they all knew not to overstep the mark with him, not if they wanted to stay.

Tamar, his wife, scurried around taking note of what was needed but not actually doing much except occasionally tending to the few women in the group. This was a bit of a treat as far as she was concerned. She could move around quietly, ears fully alert and listen to the stories these newcomers brought with them. Like walking, talking newspapers, they filled her mind with new things to share with her friends.

Yes, she was a gossip but Bina liked her. She did not mean to be threatening, even so, to Bina she was. Over the years of living and working with them, Tamar had tried to probe into her past. To a woman like Tamar, not being allowed into this

part of Bina's life was irritating, even painful; and Bina knew it. The three of them had become more like family than employers and employee so this barrier was respectfully accepted by Tamar. Most of the time the older woman did not even think of it but every now and then she would launch into a new assault, trying her best to get some answers. Bina parried deftly each time by firing some questions of her own then quickly changing the subject. When that did not work she would make an excuse to leave the room. Tamar retreated every time.

Bina breathed out, releasing a slight tension which had crept in as thoughts of the past had crept back into her mind.

DEEP DARK SECRET

Her thoughts went back to her own town. It was four days journey away by donkey, a week or two by foot, but it seemed too near for comfort sometimes. When travellers came from that direction, she would make herself scarce until she was sure they were not from her home town. Her past was gone. She wanted it to stay that way.

Her parents were poor farmers who had scraped a living from their tiny bit of land, far too small to feed the 10 children that seemed to have survived despite their meagre means. They were fortunate that a land-owner nearby needed so many young hands to work in his huge fields and also to labour in the nearby processing yards. Deft little fingers and keen eyes were valuable assets. As soon as they were able, at around 5 or 6 years of age, each of her siblings had gone off with the older children of the village to do their small share of work. At age six, Bina had joined them.

Life at first seemed fine, she was strong and hardy with an exceptionally quick and perceptive mind. Her name was very apt. 'Bina' in Hebrew meant 'Understanding' and she

seemed to be generously endowed with that gift, even at a young age. She played and romped during the breaks in work and her laughter was a pleasant change to some of the other workers.

But not everyone. Some of the older village children began to resent her free spirit and decided to tame this irritating butterfly. At first they tried taunting her but she paid no attention, only laughing at the silly things they called her. Then things got more serious. Little 'accidents' began to happen and they would blame her in public, shaking and beating her for being careless, constantly calling her 'the pest' and making sure others began to shun her. For a while it seemed to them that she had become more subdued and they continued making her life as difficult as possible. They expected that she would soon submit to them and come creeping over to curry favour. They imagined that, just like all the other kids, she would learn to toe the line. They were the top dogs here, everyone had to know their place.

It never happened. In fact, she seemed to be rising above it all and even seemed to be regaining some popularity. They had another plan.

Bina noticed that they started being much nicer to her and they would encourage her to come and work near them. They would find any and every excuse to send her over to the overseer with messages, small errands, whatever. Some of the other children knew what was going on but she didn't - how could she, evil was not something she had seen at close hand.

The first day the overseer took her for a walk in the wooded area behind the buildings, she thought it was lovely. She danced around and prattled on non-stop until things began to change. Her childish innocence was torn from her, never to return.

Once, she had tried to complain to her parents but the

beating she received from them after they had talked to the overseer, threw her into a greater despair than all the abuse she had endured. All hope seemed to vanish that day.

Years past and somehow she managed to stay sane, keeping her thoughts to herself and dreaming of a day when she could run and run and run and never look back. Now a fourteen year old girl, she dreaded the idea of marriage. Not that it was likely to happen. Her reputation was slowly degraded as others guessed what was going on though they never dared to expose the perpetrator.

On a cool moonlit night, she had sat alone in the forrest, looking up at the midnight blue sky. The stars seemed so still, so peaceful, so pure. They were not judging her. A prayer rose up from her empty heart and floated like a silent feather into the night. "My God, if you are there, help me!"

A few nights later she somehow had the overwhelming urge to break free. The dangers and fears of the unknown world beyond her village seemed to fade away and she found herself able to put a quick plan together. Pretending to go to sleep as usual, she lay down, fully clothed, and covered herself with her blanket. She waited patiently till all the family were asleep and then got up as quietly as possible. Carefully, she gathered her blanket beneath her arm and stepped gingerly over the sleeping bodies. One slip and it would be for nothing. She sighed with relief as she finally stepped outside and hurried over to the hiding place where she had hidden some food and water.

In the days that followed she walked and slept and walked and slept till finally, more than a week later, she arrived here, at the town of Bethlehem. It was early morning when she walked through the quiet streets. Outside one of the buildings in the centre, a man was grunting to himself as he threw water on the stone flagstones. He picked up a large wooden broom and half heartedly attacked the mess outside his door.

Her stomach ached for food and she saw an opportunity to get it filled. “Can I help?” she said, walking over to the man. “It will only cost you some bread and water. I am good at cleaning.” The man stopped, his eyes softening a little as he took in the state of the bedraggled slip of a girl before him. Food he had in plenty, energy he was clean out off.

He handed her the broom. “Make sure you get up all the muck and mind you throw it far from the door.” He turned again before he went inside. “Then come and eat.” That was 15 great years ago.

NEW ARRIVALS

Bina shook the thoughts of the past from her head and closed her eyes. She moved around to relieve any tension in her arms and stretched out her fingers in a fan, waving them in the air in front of her. She felt the blood rush to every part of her as she clenched her fists tightly and allowed her hand to drop onto the bed.

"This is wonderful. All that rushing around."

She stretched out her legs and wriggled her toes, feeling all the tension of the day drop away.

"Mmm, this is SO good."

It was only a matter of time before she would have to jump up and see to those folks downstairs and she listened, yes, for quite some time she would listen, enjoying the soft sound of silence.

The distant sound of hoofs was barely audible at first. They were so far away. It hardly had any effect at all on her relaxed state. She tried to avoid even hearing them but as they came closer and closer, she could not block them out. Putting her fingers in her ears only made it worse. She

listened as the hoofs stopped right outside and she heard the voices of a man and a woman.

She knew better than to go on ignoring it. Running her fingers through her hair, she rubbed her scalp then threw back her thick curls into a band behind her head.

"Lets see," she mumbled as her feet swung themselves off the bed and took her over to the window.

A man was standing in front of the door with his back to it, talking to a very young, and very pregnant, young woman sitting astride a tired donkey.

The man looked up. Judging by his clothes and trappings, Bina summed him up instantly.

"Mmm, very conservative type. I have seen his sort before - very dull, typical religious sort. Well, it's not our problem then, he certainly won't want to bed down with that rabble downstairs."

"Hello, I'll be down in a minute."

The man nodded and went back to the woman on the donkey.

Bina threw her shawl about her and made for the door. Nathanael had also heard them and was staggering out of his room.

"Oh, who's that? Not another guest. We would have to squeeze them into a cupboard if they came in!"

"No, I don't think these two would be able to stay here. It's a man and a woman and she's well, well pregnant."

"Hmm, so will you tell them or will I?"

"If you want me to, I will, but it's going to be hard for them. I don't know where else they will be able to stay. From what I've heard, everything is absolutely full."

"Oh well, let's go and see. Come on Bina, let's go, let's go and talk to them."

He opened the door with a creaking slow movement. The man on the doorstep was very polite.

"Good afternoon." He said.

Bina looked at him intently. It was very surprising because she did not expect to see what she saw there; a very kind and gentle face with eyes that were soft and smiling.

"Hi, I'm afraid you're going to be very disappointed. I'm afraid ….come in, come in and see what it's like here."

He stepped through the doorway and looked around. At once he could see the situation was hopeless.

"Ahh." He stood in silence for a while, looking around again and again. " I don't know what I am going to do," he said eventually.

Bina nodded. "There's not an inch of space here and, well, you need some kind of privacy I would say."

He looked intently at Bina and Nathanael, "I think the birth is very close, very close indeed." He looked around again and sighed. "I didn't think it would take so long, the journey. But we had to stop many times along the way and now it is very close. Too close."

Nathanael scratched his head "Aye."

Tamara poked her head out of their bedroom door. "Nathanael, what's going on?"

"Aw, nothing, nothing, just rest. We'll deal with it."

"Good," she said and disappeared back into the room.

"What are we going to do?" said the man. "By the way, my name is Joseph. I've come here because of the Census. This is my family home but most of my relatives have moved away now and it will take me at least another day to find the ones that are still here."

There was silence for a minute.

Bina looked outside and saw the young woman on the donkey's back. "Let me go and see if she needs anything."

"Her name is Mary." Said Joseph and turned back to Nathanael. "What do you think? Is there anything at all you can do?"

A DAY TO REMEMBER

What? Did you say something Bina?

Bina looked back at him. "No. Didn't say anything." Nathanael shook his head. The men continued talking.

Mary was calm and smiling as Bina reached her. She threw back the veil which had dropped over her face and pushed it back behind her head. "Hi," she said. "Bit of a mess this is, isn't it? But I am sure something will turn up."

Bina smiled at her confidence and somehow, though for the life of her she didn't know why, she totally believed her.

"Yes, I'm sure it will."

"That's it!" came Nathanael's voice. "Yes, we can use the stable - thanks for telling me."

"I didn't say a thing," said Bina once again.

"Well someone did."

The man Joseph turned round and looked at his wife Mary. They smiled, as though they were sharing a thought.

"Look, it's nothing much," he explained to the couple, "but it will get you through the night then you can go and look for your folks tomorrow."

Joseph nodded vigorously and went back to join his wife. "The Lord has provided," he whispered.

Bina was not so convinced and was already totting up in her head the items she would need to make a clean corner. Thankfully, most of their present guests had left their animals with other family members and had just come to bed down at the inn.

"Nathanael, can you take them while I get some cleaning things from the house. I will be there soon."

"Yes, yes, you go. I will show them where it is."

He hobbled down the steps. "This way." He pointed to the side of the building. "Its dug into the rock back there." He limped on around the corner with the pair following on slowly behind."

Bina went into overdrive. She grabbed a broom, a jug of water and some loose material, left over from the mattress making.

Tamara once again came out to investigate. "What a lot of noise. What was Nath shouting about? Did I hear him say something about the stables?"

Bina did not want to waste time but she put down her bundles and explained to Tamara what had been happening.

"Pregnant! ….. In the stable! Oh, this is nonsense. I am going to see what is going on." She closed the door quickly behind her as she scurried to get hold of her shawl and outdoor shoes.

Bina was hardly a few steps away from the house when Tamara caught up and hurried past her. Her words floated back to Bina on the cold air. "This won't do, everyone will be talking about us. Who puts a woman in a stable"

Bina turned and watched her as she marched down the road towards the stable. she felt a pang of worry inside her and she had no idea why she felt this way. it was as though something good was being threatened.

"Oh I hope she calms down!"

she turned again and went quickly into the inn to gather the things she needed, hoping that Tamara would not have undone all the arrangements that had been made.

It took her about five minutes to gather what she needed and get back to the stable. When she did, she was totally unprepared for what she saw. The young woman, Mary, was sitting on the milking stool and beside her, kneeling on the floor, was Tamara, her arm around the girl's shoulder gently soothing her and talking and chatting with her as though they both knew each other all their lives. Chatting, laughing and smiling. Yes, Tamara was smiling as though she had no worries in the world and had just found her long lost daughter, if she had one.

Joseph and Nathaniel meanwhile, were working together like a well oiled team, pulling bales of hay this way and that. They were making a barrier between the one or two animals that were in the stable creating a nice, warm, sheltered corner which had been totally cleared out.

Tamara looked up as Bina entered. "Ah Bina, quickly, go over and clean so that we can put down some fresh straw. Yes, yes, come on, quickly now."

Bina laughed. "OK, I'm on it."

She strode over to the corner and started sweeping. In no time, what looked like a fairly cosy room had been created, a wall of hay bales on one side and the rough stone of the cave on the other. They made a shelf of flat packed straw at the far end between the two 'walls' and threw one of the heavy blankets Bina had brought over on top of it.

"At least they will have somewhere to sleep now," said Bina.

Tamara smiled and nodded "But what about the baby?"

Bina sighed and looked around the stable. An animal feeding trough stood near the entrance. She went over and

tossed every bit of old hay and food onto the floor and gave it a good scrub. “Nathanael, can you haul this over to the corner?”

“Yes, what is it for?”

“It’s for the baby - when it comes..”

“Mmm, well, I suppose it’s the right shape. But it doesn’t look much good to me right now.”

“It will when I’m finished,” She was getting excited about how everything was shaping up.

Once in place, Bina put some soft clean straw in the bottom of the manger and draped another cloth over it.

“There, that will do nicely.”

Mary turned and smiled, “Yes, I think that will be good.” She suddenly clasped her tummy.

“I think it is just in time,” she half whispered half squeaked, holding hard onto Tamara’s arm.

Tamara looked full into Mary’s face. “Oh, oh, oh,” she stood up and held her more securely. “Come, come lets get you over there.”

Mary rose slowly, Tamara’s hand gently supporting her.

“Bina, go quickly and ask Sarah to get her birthing stool.” She turned for a second and looked at Mary. “My knees are not strong enough I’m afraid!” She smiled as she saw the look on Mary’s face. “Maybe in my young days!” She turned to shout more instructions at Bina who was fast disappearing out of the entrance. “And some hot water, oil and towels”. Bina spun round for a second. “And some salt and wine I think,”

“Yes, but hurry. Sarah will know.”

Bina dashed away. Tamara was in full swing. She turned to see Joseph and Nathanael looking on “Nathanael, take Joseph into the inn, we need some privacy here.” Mary interrupted, “It’s all right, they can stay.”

Tamara patted Mary's arm fondly, "No, no child, men are not allowed." She laughed a little

"I can see you are new to this."

"Not really, I helped my cousin just recently, but I thought it might be good for Joseph to be around." Tamara was adamant, the men must go.

Joseph bent over to talk to Mary "What do you think, I will stay if you want me to."

"No, perhaps it is better if you go. I think it will upset them if you stay. Don't worry, I'll be all right, I have no problems. I feel really good." Joseph knelt down beside her for a minute. He looked deep into her eyes. "Praise be to God. Blessed be the God of Abraham, Issac and Jacob." "Amen," said Mary.

"Come said Nathanael. Let's leave the women to their work. I'll get a nice jug of good wine ready for the celebration."

"That's great" said Joseph. He looked at Mary, letting go of her hand slowly as he turned to go.

She smiled and nodded, watching him as he looked back at her again several times on his way out of the cave. Nathanael nudged him forwards and they were gone.

Tamara sat down gently beside Mary. They sat quietly together for a few moments.

"How relaxed you are," Tamara said softly, studying Mary's face, wondering a little at her composure.

"Isn't God watching," said Mary. "He will see that it all goes well."

Tamara smiled and nodded. "Maybe so, but he won't be rolling up his sleeves and getting things ready." She patted Mary's hand. "I had better get on with that." She turned to see Bina struggling into the entrance, balancing a bowl of water on top of a birthing stool and some clean clothes draped around her shoulders. "Oh child, let me take them!"

she rose and strode quickly over to her, grabbing hold of the bowl of water and laying it gently on a stone ledge.

For the next five minutes Tamara and Bina were busying themselves sorting out the various articles while Bina searched in her deep pockets for the oil and some other items she had gathered from the midwife.

Both had their backs turned when they heard a soft moan from behind them.

"We're coming," called Tamara reassuringly.

Then they both whirled round instantly as the sound of a baby's first cry filled the air.

"What!"

Both women stood like a pair of frozen sculptures, bottle in one hand, cloth in another, mouths open in astonishment as they saw Mary gently lift the infant close to her.

Instinctively, both women grabbed what they could and rushed over to Mary.

"Amazing, amazing," was all that Tamara could manage.

Bina quickly wrapped the child in the clean cloths she had brought and as she did so, all questions within her stopped. In fact, such a silence took hold of her that she seemed to be floating in a space that was unlike anything she had known. The silence travelled into her thoughts, into her memories, into the dark, hidden parts that she kept shut to keep out the world. But it could not keep out what was entering into her. She felt it embracing all the secret agonies, rejection, humiliation and loneliness that had been locked inside. She continued to wrap the child, looking down at his little face and tears dropped silently from her lowered eyes. Mary saw and smiled. "Thank you," she whispered as she took the child from her.

Tamara was dealing with the afterbirth which had also arrived so instantly. She placed it into an empty bowl to let

the cord dry out and turned her attention back to the mother.

Only then did she notice Bina's tear stained face and the torrent of questions she was about to launch, vanished. She looked from one to the other; the mother and baby, totally at peace, Bina, her face wet with tears but her eyes shining like the morning sun.

Tamara moved gently forwards. "He is beautiful" she whispered.

Mary looked up and nodded and kissed his forehead. "His name is Jesus,"

"Jesus," Tamara repeated and laid her hand gently on the tiny wrapped bundle.

She kept it there for some time, not wanting to move it. It felt good, really good, as if she had touched home and all was well.

She collected herself and drew in a deep breath. "Well," she said, "we had better go and tell the men."

She started to tidy the area around Mary and tapped Bina on the arm. "You go off and tell them, I will finish up here."

Bina walked slowly towards the entrance, glancing back at Mary and the child as she went. Tamara and she had started talking to each other and by the time Bina had reached the entrance she noticed they were already deep in conversation.

Bina smiled to herself and knew in her heart that this was the best thing that could possible happen to Tamara. Why, she did not know, she just knew that this was a conversation that would change Tamara's life.

She took her time as she walked towards the inn. Give them a little time, she thought.

"He has arrived!" she announced as she walked in the door.

Nathanael was amazed "So quickly?" He had not even

settled down properly and was still placing things on the table in front of Joseph.

Joseph shot to his feet and lifted his hands. "Alleluia! Thank you Bina. You are blessed."

Bina smiled and said quietly to herself, "Yes."

She did not follow them as they disappeared out the door but after a few minutes went outside to find her favourite 'thinking place' . It was a small grove of trees near the inn which gave her a good view of the countryside. She sat down on a rock and gazed up to the sky. There were no words in her mind, only the silence and the peace that had replaced the niggling ache that used to colour her world.

Then she saw something new, a huge bright star which hung like a lantern in the night sky. Even God has put on a welcome sign for this baby she thought. She sat there in complete peace and silence for the next hour until the sound of footsteps and voices grew louder and louder behind her.

They were coming from the small dirt footpath that led from the countryside into the town. No one used this path except the shepherd folk who worked out on the hills. They were a rough lot, not people you wanted to associate with. People who decent folk shunned, dirty and uneducated. She did not mind them too much, they were not dangerous but they didn't like mixing with the townsfolk, no more than the townsfolk liked mixing with them.

She turned as they entered the grove, about ten of them in exited conversation. They spotted her and came forward. She stiffened a little but smiled at them.

The leader of the small group took off his hat and nodded.

"Miss," he said in his rough country accent. "You wouldn't by any chance know where we can find a baby that was born tonight in a stable here?" She stared in complete amazement at the man.

"Well, no, I suppose not, you must think its a bit of a strange question but…"

"No, no," she broke in, "its a good question. "I know where. Why are you asking?"

The man brightened up at her reply and turned and looked at his companions. "Shall I tell her?"

"Yes, go ahead," said one of his group nodding vigorously and coming to stand beside them both.

The old shepherd took a deep breath.

"We were there, all minding our sheep in different places on the hill."

"I was cooking my supper," interrupted another from behind.

"Yes, all minding our own business when we heard this singing. In the air it was." He waived his arms above him. "Beautiful it was, like nothing you have ever heard. Then light, light everywhere and a man was up in the sky. A shining man, beautiful he was too. He told us that he was bringing us really good news. He told us that this very night our saviour was born here in Bethlehem - right here, right in our town. I don't know what that means to be honest. I don't know what a saviour is and I didn't know who he was but he that we would find him wrapped up in his birth cloths and lying in a feeding trough in a stable here. Seemed a bit strange to me and I was not sure who this guy was. To be honest it scared me. Then he said I wasn't to be frightened and the singing got louder and suddenly we all saw thousands of beautiful people all singing like it was a great big special festival event up there. Then it all faded away and we came running to the others to ask if anyone else had seen it. Everyone had seen the same thing so we wondered what we should do about it. So, we decided to come. That's it."

Bina stood up. "Come, she said, laughing a little but

putting her arm around the old man. "I will take you to him. I was there when he was born."

"Really!"

She giggled again. "Yes, really. I think God sent me here to wait for you."

The men looked at each other and exchanged glances. "Lead on."

She had no fears leading these men to the young couple and their baby. God had arranged this personally, she was happy to do her bit. She left them together, telling their story to the couple while each took turns to hold the babe in their arms or gently touch its head for a minute or two. As she left them, some of them were crying and kneeling down in the straw. Others were just standing around rooted to the spot and gazing silently at the child.

The following evening they said goodbye to Joseph, Mary and their new baby. They carried on their way into the heart of the town to meet up with Joseph's relatives.

Despite their busy day, both Tamara and Bina managed to have a little more time to visit the stable, each taking turns holding the baby and sing to him.

Nathanael too had popped over there when things got quiet in the afternoon. In his hand was a large jug of good country wine, keeping his promise to Joseph. After a glass or two, he and Joseph had sat talking together for longer than he had spent talking to anyone in years. What they talked about he wouldn't say but he sighed a little when the couple left.

The following days seemed to be a dizzy round of noise, work and good business. As soon as one group left, another wave of guests would turn up. The census officials had stayed for a few more days and those families who had waited to the last minute, turned up just for the day. The afternoons were no longer quiet times. All day, weary trav-

ellers came asking for refreshments before heading back to Jerusalem. Nathanael was certainly not going to refuse them. He did a roaring trade in wine and warm fresh bread.

As quickly as it had all started, it all stopped. Silence, sanity and normal living returned to the the small town. The crowds that had swarmed through the streets, melted away, returning to countryside villages and hamlets that had been too small to warrant a census official of their own.

The inn slipped back to its normal routine. Market day, occasional visitors, baking bread for some regular customers, little groups of men chatting outside in the cool of the evening and everything seemed to be as it was before. But it wasn't. The routines were the same but the people had changed.

Tamara's friends were a little annoyed with her. They had enjoyed listening to her gossip but she no longer indulged them. She never said why but she would simply stay quiet when this or that person was being discussed. In time, they started to enjoy her company again for another reason. They felt safe to confide in her. In private they would share honest and heartfelt confidences about themselves. No one could be trusted more to keep their secrets and her advice was always appreciated. If she could not suggest a sensible answer to their dilemmas, her advice was always the same. "God, blessed be his name, is always listening. Talk to Him and ask him to help." She was already a gregarious person but people noticed that she smiled a lot more these days and her laugh was infectious.

Bina had noticed the difference too and had approached her one day. Together they walked to the grove of trees and together they remembered that wonderful night. It was time, Bina thought, to let go and open the door of her heart. "There is something I want to share with you," said Bina.

"Then you will understand me a little more." Tamara took hold of both of her hands,

"Yes, I know there is but you don't have to if you don't want to."

"I do want to. I want to very much." Bit by bit Bina revealed her story to Tamara, weeping and laughing at the same time. There was a joy in being able to open that door, a joy she never expected. The past pain flew to freedom like a trapped bird, flying into the sunlight for the first time. She found that she was truly giving thanks to God for a wonderful gift. Tamara smiled broadly and hugged her. "One day I will tell you my own story but not now, now it is you we are celebrating today. You have found a new home. I have found a new daughter."

"Yes," whispered Bina and threw her arms around her. Tamara hugged her close then, holding both of her arms pushed her back so that both women were looking directly at each other. "Bina, you are now the daughter I never had. Right?"

Bina smiled and gently nodded her consent. "Yes, that seems just right to me."

In the fading sunlight under the trees, in a quiet grove in Bethlehem, two women sat silently. Both of them were looking at the sky as the stars began to show, one by one. No one wanted to move. Neither needed to say another word. They sat together, still and content.

This was yet another night to remember.

PROLOGUE

Over a year and a few months had passed since the visitors had arrived for the census. Mary and Joseph had returned to Mary's hometown but had told Tamara that they would be returning again for the Passover festival the following year.

Bina had found out where their relatives lived in Bethlehem and she and Tamara had gone to see them. Jesus was now a young toddler and was walking, somewhat unsteadily around the courtyard. Everyone loved him and they spent the next hour or two chatting happily with household members as they played with him and drank warm lemon tea in the cool air.

News had got round that a caravan of foreign visitors had been seen in Jerusalem and had been received by King Herod. The last report was that, for some unknown reason, they were now on their way to Bethlehem.

Tamara and Bina said their goodbyes and left the family, heading back to the inn in case they were needed to help with the servants or retinue of these important people. Theirs was the only inn for many miles.

Somehow, it was no surprise when they arrived and asked after the child who was born in their stable. They asked at what time he was born and the exact location where the birth took place. The questions just kept coming. "Did you notice any other occurrence that night."

Bina nodded vigorously and told them about the shepherds and the star that suddenly appeared just after the birth.

The men went into a deep discussion and pulled out heavy books and charts, pouring over them as they nodded and murmured. They spread one or two of the maps on the dining table and used metal instruments to measure points and lines.

They finally looked up. "Is he still in Bethlehem?" they asked.

Bina and Tamara both nodded.

Tamara looked at Bina. She did not say a word but it was obvious what she was asking. "Should we, is it safe?"

Bina whispered "Yes".

That day, they walked them through the winding streets, right to the house where they stayed.

"And going into the house they saw the child with his mother Mary, and falling to their knees they did him homage. Then, opening their treasures, they offered him gifts of gold and frankincense and myrrh." Matthew 2:11

It was reported later that the couple suddenly left unexpectedly right after the visitors had departed back to their own country.

It seemed to Bina and Tamara that they must have been warned in some way since they escaped the terrible event that overtook the small town just a week later.

It was a sword that pierced every heart in Bethlehem and one that would be remembered for a long time.

Life and normal living would return again but without many of its young inhabitants.

Many, many years later, Bina was to know why that child had to be spared the slaughter of that day.

As she sat on a hillside, listening to the words of Jesus of Nazareth, she knew that the shepherds had been right.

She had found her saviour.